2026 MLB Undervalued Hitters

Statcast expected-performance screening | Portfolio scouting & analytics report

Prepared by: Corey Bannerman **Analysis:** 2026 season leaderboard exports **Sample:** 406 hitters

Executive summary

This study screens 406 MLB hitters for gaps between observed production and Statcast expected metrics. The purpose is to identify players whose batted-ball outcomes may have lagged the quality of their underlying contact, then use contact-quality measures to distinguish promising follow-up candidates from potentially misleading gaps.

Primary follow-up candidate: Edouard Julien. Julien paired a +.051 xwOBA gap and +.109 xSLG gap with a 49.7% hard-hit rate (93rd percentile within the analyzed player pool). His profile provides both an outcome gap and supporting evidence of frequent hard contact.

Largest statistical discrepancy: Ke'Bryan Hayes. Hayes posted the largest gaps of the five finalists (+.095 xBA, +.146 xSLG and +.096 xwOBA). However, his 38.5% hard-hit rate and 6.7% barrel rate do not independently signal top-tier contact quality. He is worth investigating, not automatically projecting for a breakout.

Interpretation: A positive expected-minus-actual gap is a screening signal, not proof of bad luck, future improvement, or below-market contract value. Player roles, swing decisions, strikeouts, health, defense, salary and acquisition cost are outside this dataset.

Finalist snapshot

Hitter	PA	BIP	xBA gap	xSLG gap	xwOBA gap
Ke'Bryan Hayes	242	179	+0.095	+0.146	+0.096
Edouard Julien	276	165	+0.039	+0.109	+0.051
Edwin Arroyo	160	113	+0.045	+0.084	+0.051
Leo Jimenez	194	130	+0.043	+0.077	+0.047
Patrick Bailey	345	224	+0.034	+0.063	+0.036

Source: Baseball Savant / Statcast, user-exported 2026 leaderboards. Differences are calculated from displayed rounded statistics.

1 | Data and methodology

Source and sample

Two Baseball Savant batting leaderboards were downloaded for 2026: Expected Statistics and Exit Velocity & Barrels. The Expected Statistics export was filtered to a minimum of 100 balls in play (BIP); the contact leaderboard used a minimum of 100 batted-ball events (BBE). The tables were joined by player ID. The resulting analysis contained 406 unique hitters. The R validation showed a minimum of 100 BIP, zero players below that threshold, no duplicate IDs, and no missing values in the principal expected-production and contact-quality columns.

The screenshots confirmed the 2026 season and minimum thresholds but did not expose an explicit regular-season/postseason selection. Accordingly, this report refers to the **2026 leaderboard exports**; the precise game-type scope should be verified from source documentation or export metadata before labeling the analysis definitively regular-season-only.

Key metrics

xBA, xSLG and xwOBA: Statcast expected outcomes based on batted-ball characteristics, with xwOBA also accounting for walks, strikeouts and hit-by-pitches. **Gap:** expected statistic minus actual statistic; positive values indicate observed outcomes below expected outcomes. **Barrel rate:** percentage of batted-ball events classified as barrels. **Hard-hit rate:** share of batted balls struck at 95 mph or more.

Screening approach

The analysis ranked hitters by positive xBA, xSLG and xwOBA gaps, visualized the full sample, and compared five selected candidates. Contact quality was then used as a secondary check. The five players are a **focused exploratory shortlist**, not a formal model-generated top five or a causal estimate of future performance.

2 | Analytical limitations

Expected statistics are descriptive estimates, not guaranteed forecasts. Park effects, spray angle, foot speed, defensive positioning, swing decisions, strikeout and walk profiles, and changes in playing time can influence realized outcomes. Sample sizes vary meaningfully: Edwin Arroyo has 160 PA versus Patrick Bailey's 345 PA. Differences in exposure increase uncertainty when comparing players. The study does not use uncertainty intervals, multiyear projections, contract costs, or scouting observations.

Percentiles in the R dashboard are relative to the 406-player dataset, not necessarily official MLB percentile rankings. They depend on the selected thresholds and metric definitions. The term **undervalued** here refers to potential underperformance against expected metrics, not demonstrated economic undervaluation.

3 | Where expected outcomes exceed actual results

All five finalists had positive xwOBA gaps. Hayes was the clear leader by magnitude, while Julien and Arroyo were tied at +.051. These differences are best treated as reasons for further review rather than direct forecasts of rebound size.

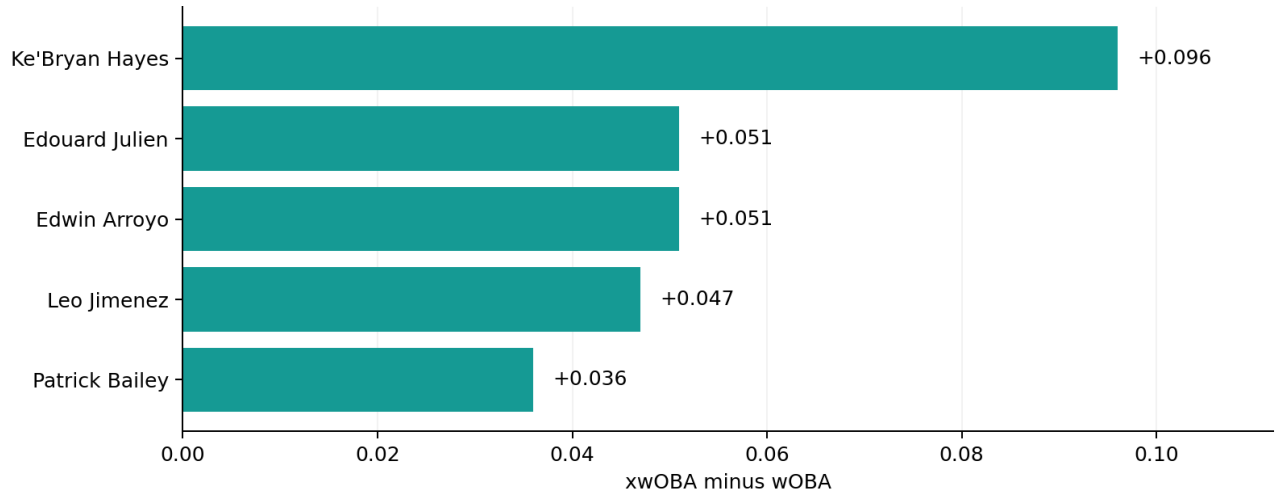


Figure 1. xwOBA minus actual wOBA for five selected hitters. Reconstructed from the verified final-candidate table, rather than exported directly from R.



Figure 2. Comparison of xBA, xSLG and xwOBA gaps. The scales of these metrics differ; bar heights should be compared primarily *within* each metric.

4 | Candidate evaluations

Edouard Julien | Best contact-quality follow-up

Julien recorded a .208 BA versus .247 xBA, .292 SLG versus .401 xSLG, and .287 wOBA versus .338 xwOBA across 276 PA and 165 BIP. His 49.7% hard-hit rate and 7.3% barrel rate make him a compelling next-look candidate. His hard-hit rate ranks at the 93rd percentile within the project dataset. Further study should examine strikeouts, swing decisions, launch-angle distribution and whether the hard contact is translating into useful game power.

Ke'Bryan Hayes | Largest gaps; mixed quality-of-contact signal

Hayes posted a .141 BA against .236 xBA, .225 SLG against .371 xSLG, and .191 wOBA against .287 xwOBA in 242 PA. His +.096 xwOBA gap is the largest of the finalists, but his 38.5% hard-hit rate and 6.7% barrel rate are not elite within this sample. A deeper investigation should test whether weak-contact frequency, launch angle, speed or situational factors explain the mismatch.

Patrick Bailey | More exposure, smaller gaps

Bailey had the largest sample of the five at 345 PA and 224 BIP. His .206 BA versus .240 xBA and .271 wOBA versus .307 xwOBA suggest some underperformance, while a 42.4% hard-hit rate and 7.6% barrel rate provide moderate supporting contact evidence. His larger sample makes him useful as a comparison case, though the +.036 xwOBA gap is smaller than those of the leading candidates.

Leo Jimenez | Modest but consistent discrepancies

Jimenez recorded a .199 BA versus .242 xBA, .259 SLG versus .336 xSLG, and .267 wOBA versus .314 xwOBA over 194 PA. His 40.0% hard-hit rate and 3.8% barrel rate are mixed. Further evaluation should prioritize how often he generates impact contact and whether his batted-ball profile supports additional slugging.

Edwin Arroyo | Strong xBA, weaker contact-quality support

Arroyo had a .223 BA versus .268 xBA and a .240 wOBA versus .291 xwOBA over 160 PA. His 2.7% barrel rate and 27.4% hard-hit rate are the lowest among the finalists. Despite an 86th-percentile xBA in the project dashboard, his low hard-hit rate and smaller sample suggest caution. Bat-to-ball skills, speed and batted-ball placement warrant review before drawing conclusions.

5 | Contact quality and recommendations

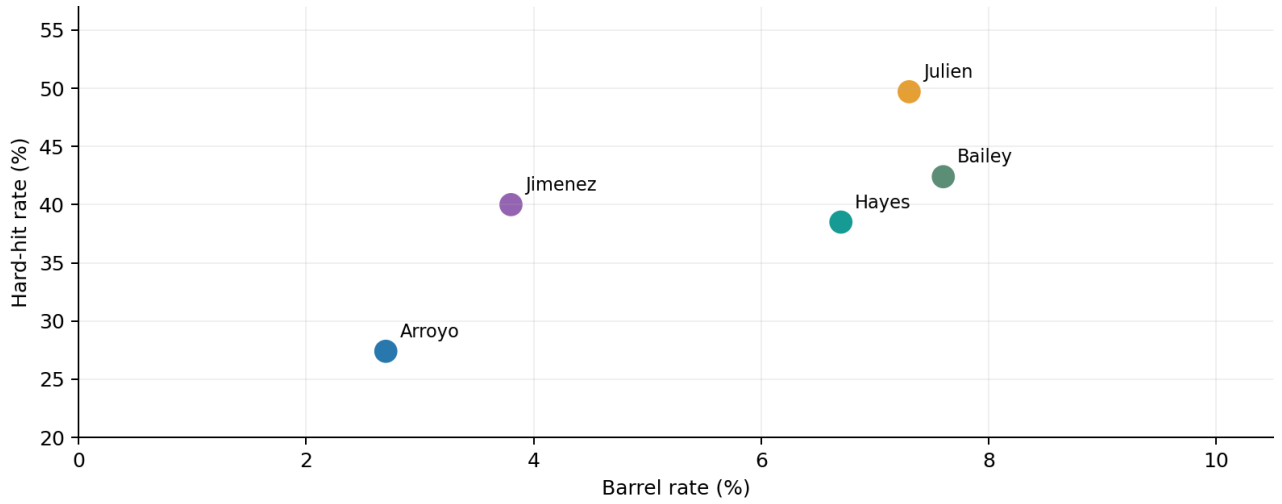


Figure 3. Contact-quality comparison for the five finalists, reconstructed from the final-candidate statistics. Higher values indicate more barrels and more hard-hit balls, but neither measure alone establishes future value.

Prioritized next steps

1. Review Julien first. Evaluate swing decisions, strikeout rate, launch-angle mix, handedness splits and monthly trends to determine whether hard contact is sustainable and actionable.

2. Investigate Hayes' extreme gaps. Compare hit types, speed, spray direction and batted-ball distributions before interpreting his expected-stat differential as a rebound signal.

3. Use Bailey as a stability comparison. His higher PA and BIP totals make him useful for checking how gap size changes with sample size. Review the offensive value in the context of his defensive role.

4. Keep Jimenez and Arroyo on a watchlist. Examine more detailed contact and plate-discipline measures; Arroyo especially requires caution because of limited hard contact and smaller exposure.

Conclusion

The clearest finding is that **large expected-stat gaps and strong contact quality are not the same thing**. Hayes has the largest discrepancies, while Julien has the most compelling combination of underperformance and hard-hit frequency in this shortlist. Both deserve additional review, but no candidate can be declared financially undervalued without salary, contract, role and projection information. This workflow demonstrates a reproducible way to turn Statcast leaderboards into a disciplined first-pass scouting shortlist.

Data: Baseball Savant / Statcast, 2026 Expected Statistics and Exit Velocity & Barrels leaderboards. **Analysis:** R, dplyr/tidyverse and ggplot2. **Portfolio:** github.com/coreybann.